

Physical Activity for Lifelong Health: How Much You Need and How to Start Safely — Free Preview

FRONT MATTER

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Physical Activity for Lifelong Health: How Much You Need and How to Start Safely

CHAPTER 1

Learning Objectives

By the end of this interactive lesson, you will be able to:

1. Explain the basic physical activity targets for adults, children, and adolescents.
2. Tell the difference between moderate and vigorous activity using practical cues like the talk test.
3. Identify examples of aerobic, muscle-strengthening, and bone-strengthening activities.
4. Create a realistic weekly activity plan that fits your ability, schedule, health needs, and environment.
5. Recognize warning symptoms that mean you should stop activity and seek medical guidance.
6. Apply the memory formula: Move most days, strengthen twice weekly, start small, progress gradually.

CHAPTER 2

Opening Hook: The Health Habit That Compounds

You do not need to become an athlete to gain real health benefits

from physical activity.

A short walk, a few strength exercises, dancing in your living room, gardening, pushing a stroller, rolling your wheelchair, taking the stairs, or doing chair-based movement can all count.

The key is consistency.

> Memory Formula™:

> Move most days, strengthen twice weekly, start small, progress gradually.

This lesson will help you understand how much activity is recommended, how to tell whether your effort is moderate or vigorous, how to choose safe activities, and how to build a weekly plan that works in real life.

CHAPTER 3

Important Safety Note

General physical activity targets are helpful, but they are not a personal medical prescription.

Your safest starting point depends on factors such as:

- Current fitness level

- Age

- Pregnancy or postpartum status

- Disability or mobility needs

- Injury or pain

- Heart, lung, metabolic, neurological, or joint conditions

- Medications that affect heart rate, balance, blood pressure, or

blood sugar

Recent surgery, illness, or hospitalization

If you have a chronic condition, are pregnant or recently postpartum, have symptoms with activity, or are unsure what is safe for you, speak with a qualified healthcare professional before beginning or increasing activity.

CHAPTER 4

Adults

For most adults, the general weekly target is:

150–300 minutes per week of moderate-intensity aerobic activity, or

75–150 minutes per week of vigorous-intensity aerobic activity, or

An equivalent combination of moderate and vigorous activity
plus

Muscle-strengthening activities at least 2 days per week

Adults should also:

Reduce sedentary time

Break up long periods of sitting when possible

Accumulate activity in shorter sessions throughout the week

You do not have to complete long workouts for activity to count. Several shorter sessions can add up.

Examples:

Three 10-minute walks in one day

A 15-minute morning walk plus 15 minutes of evening cycling

Five 30-minute sessions across the week

Ten-minute movement breaks during work or caregiving routines

> Remember: Move most days, strengthen twice weekly, start small, progress gradually.

CHAPTER 5

Children and Adolescents Ages 6–17

The general goal for children and teens is:

An average of at least 60 minutes per day of moderate-to-vigorous physical activity

This should include:

Vigorous activity at least 3 days per week

Muscle-strengthening activity at least 3 days per week

Bone-strengthening activity at least 3 days per week

Children do not need formal workouts. Play, sports, active transportation, playground time, dancing, running games, climbing, and jumping activities can all count.

CHAPTER 6

Inactive Beginners

If you are inactive, the most important message is:

> Some physical activity is better than none. Health benefits begin even below the full guideline amounts.

You do not need to reach the full target immediately. Begin where you are.

A safe starting point may be:

5 minutes of walking

3 minutes of chair movement

One light strength exercise

Gentle mobility work

One short movement break per day

Then build gradually.

CHAPTER 7

Learner Checkpoint

Before moving on, complete this sentence:

> My first realistic movement step could be:

>

Examples:

“Walk for 5 minutes after lunch.”

“Do chair exercises during one TV break.”

“Take a short movement break every afternoon.”

“Try one beginner strength routine twice this week.”

Physical activity is one of the most powerful daily habits for long-term health.

For adults, the basic target is regular aerobic movement such as walking, cycling, swimming, dancing, wheelchair propulsion, or active chores, combined with strengthening work at least twice each week.

For children and teens, growing bodies need frequent movement. The target is higher: about an hour a day on average, with a mix of activities that raise the heart rate, strengthen muscles, and load the bones in healthy ways.

If you are inactive, recovering from injury, pregnant, older, disabled, or living with a chronic condition, the goal is not to “push through.” The goal is to choose appropriate movement, start small, progress gradually, and seek medical guidance when symptoms or health concerns suggest it is needed.

> QRU Translation:

> Do not wait for the perfect workout. Build a movement habit that fits your real life and your real body.

> Move most days, strengthen twice weekly, start small, progress gradually.

Use this as your simple lifelong health formula:

Formula Step	What It Means	Practical Example
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Move most days	Build regular aerobic activity into your week.	
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Walk, roll, cycle, swim, dance, garden, or do active chores.		
--	--	--

Strengthen twice weekly	Train major muscle groups at least 2	
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days per week. Squats to a chair, wall push-ups, resistance bands, weights, or bodyweight exercises.

Start small Begin at a level your body can tolerate. 5–10 minutes, light effort, or fewer repetitions.

Progress gradually Increase time, frequency, or intensity step by step. Add 5 minutes, one extra day, or slightly more challenge over time.

CHAPTER 8

Quick Recall Prompt

Without looking back, fill in the blanks:

> Move most days, strengthen ____ weekly, start __, progress ____.

Answer: twice, small, gradually

Regular physical activity is linked with lower risk of:

Cardiovascular disease

Type 2 diabetes

Some cancers

Depression and anxiety symptoms

Cognitive decline

Falls and fall-related injuries

Premature death

It also supports:

Better sleep

Stronger bones and muscles
Improved balance and coordination
Healthier blood pressure and blood sugar control
Better mood and energy
Greater independence with daily activities

Physical activity is not only about athletic fitness. It is about helping your body, brain, and daily life function better over time.

CHAPTER 9

Everyday Analogy

Physical activity is like charging a battery.

Small, regular charges keep the whole system working better than waiting until the battery is nearly empty and trying to fix everything at once.

A 10-minute walk, a few chair exercises, a short dance break, or a gentle mobility routine may seem small, but repeated consistently, these “charges” add up.

> Memory Reminder:

> Move most days. Strengthen twice weekly. Start small. Progress gradually.

Physical activity intensity describes how hard your body is working.

The two most common intensity levels are:

Moderate intensity

Vigorous intensity

Both can improve health. The right choice depends on your current fitness, health history, preferences, and goals.

CHAPTER 10

Moderate-Intensity Activity

During moderate activity:

Your heart rate and breathing increase.

You can talk, but you may not want to sing.

You feel like you are working, but you are not near your maximum effort.

Examples may include:

Brisk walking

Easy cycling

Water aerobics

Dancing at a comfortable pace

Gardening or yard work

Doubles tennis

Active housework

Pushing a stroller at a steady pace

Wheelchair propulsion at a steady pace

CHAPTER 11

Vigorous-Intensity Activity

During vigorous activity:

Your heart rate and breathing increase a lot.

Talking becomes difficult.

You can say only a few words before needing to breathe.

The effort feels challenging.

Examples may include:

Running or jogging

Fast cycling

Swimming laps

Singles tennis

Hiking uphill

Jump rope

Fast dancing

High-intensity interval training, if appropriate

Competitive sports

Vigorous activity is not necessary for everyone, and it may not be the best starting point for beginners or people with certain health conditions.

The talk test is a practical way to estimate intensity without equipment.

If You Can... Your Intensity Is Likely...

Sing comfortably Light

Talk but not sing Moderate

Say only a few words at a time Vigorous

Barely speak or feel distressed Too intense; slow down or stop

CHAPTER 12

Knowledge Check 1

You are walking at a pace where you can speak in full sentences, but singing would be difficult.

What intensity is this most likely?

- A. Light
- B. Moderate
- C. Vigorous
- D. Too intense

Answer: B. Moderate

CHAPTER 13

Knowledge Check 2

You are cycling so hard that you can only say two or three words before needing to breathe.

What intensity is this most likely?

- A. Light
- B. Moderate
- C. Vigorous
- D. Sedentary

Answer: C. Vigorous

CHAPTER 14

Reflection Prompt

Think of one activity you already do or could realistically start.

Activity: _____

Using the talk test, this activity is usually:

- ☐ Light
- ☐ Moderate
- ☐ Vigorous
- ☐ It depends on my pace

A balanced activity routine usually includes three categories:

1. Aerobic activity
2. Muscle-strengthening activity
3. Bone-strengthening activity

Some activities fit more than one category.

CHAPTER 15

A. Aerobic Activity

Aerobic activity uses large muscle groups and raises your heart rate and breathing.

Examples:

- Walking
- Hiking
- Cycling

Swimming
Dancing
Jogging or running
Rowing
Skating
Active games
Water aerobics
Wheelchair propulsion
Low-impact cardio videos
Sports such as basketball, soccer, tennis, or pickleball
Active chores such as raking leaves or mowing with a push mower

Aerobic activity is the main category used to meet the weekly minute target for adults.

CHAPTER 16

B. Muscle-Strengthening Activity

Muscle-strengthening activity makes your muscles work against resistance.

Adults should aim for strengthening activities at least 2 days per week, involving major muscle groups such as:

Legs
Hips
Back
Chest
Abdomen

Shoulders

Arms

Examples:

Lifting weights

Resistance band exercises

Bodyweight exercises

Wall push-ups

Chair squats or sit-to-stands

Step-ups

Lunges, if appropriate

Planks or modified planks

Carrying groceries

Heavy gardening

Climbing activities

Pilates-style strengthening

Wheelchair push-ups or seated resistance exercises

For beginners, strengthening does not need to be complicated. One set of 8–12 comfortable repetitions of a few exercises can be a starting point.

CHAPTER 17

C. Bone-Strengthening Activity

Bone-strengthening activities create healthy impact or loading forces on bones.

These are especially emphasized for children and adolescents, but adults may also benefit from appropriate bone-loading activities

depending on health status and injury risk.

Examples for children and teens:

- Jumping
- Hopping
- Skipping
- Running
- Basketball
- Soccer
- Gymnastics
- Tennis
- Jump rope
- Playground climbing

Examples for adults, if appropriate:

- Brisk walking
- Stair climbing
- Hiking
- Dancing
- Resistance training
- Jogging or running, if joints and health status allow
- Low-impact strength and balance work for those who should avoid jumping

People with osteoporosis, joint problems, balance issues, pregnancy-related concerns, or injury history should ask a healthcare professional which bone-strengthening activities are appropriate.

CHAPTER 18

Learner Checkpoint: Sort the Activity

Place each activity into one or more categories: aerobic, muscle-strengthening, bone-strengthening.

Activity	Aerobic	Muscle-Strengthening	Bone-Strengthening
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Brisk walking	☐	☐	☐
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Resistance band rows	☐	☐	☐
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Jump rope	☐	☐	☐
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Swimming laps	☐	☐	☐
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Chair sit-to-stands	☐	☐	☐
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Dancing	☐	☐	☐
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18.1 Suggested Answers

Activity	Likely Category
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Brisk walking	Aerobic; may provide some bone-loading
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Resistance band rows	Muscle-strengthening
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Jump rope	Aerobic and bone-strengthening
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Swimming laps	Aerobic
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Chair sit-to-stands	Muscle-strengthening
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Dancing	Aerobic; may be bone-strengthening depending on style
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Physical activity is important, but so is reducing long periods of sitting or inactivity.

Sedentary time includes:

- Sitting at a desk for long periods

- Watching TV for hours without movement

Long car rides

Extended screen time

Sitting or lying down for most of the day while awake

You do not have to eliminate sitting. Instead, look for small ways to interrupt it.

Examples:

Stand or move for 1–3 minutes every 30–60 minutes.

Walk during phone calls.

Stretch during TV breaks.

Do chair marches or ankle circles.

Park farther away if safe and practical.

Take one extra trip up the stairs.

Use a reminder alarm for movement breaks.

> Memory Reminder:

> Move most days does not only mean planned workouts. It also means adding movement into ordinary days.

CHAPTER 19

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